

Making An Impression



Continued evolution in printers and MFDs has ensured improved features and reduced prices. So, which is the right one for you?

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It's been roughly a year since our previous laser printer tests and boy, have the markets changed since then! During this period, the fight between inkjets and lasers has intensified, but the laser camp is rejoicing—they have some solid, positive reasons working for them.

Gone are the days when laser printers were the domain of only the rich multinational corporations that had the capacity to shell out way too much money for bulky, ugly-looking devices, which seemed more appropriate in a boxing ring than in a swanky office.

Even in terms of market size, the equation has changed. The market has grown tremendously, as a recent survey revealed. According to a survey by US-based research agency AMI, Indian small and medium businesses spent nearly half a billion dollars on printers in FY 04-05. What's more, the market is expected to grow at a fair clip of about 20 per cent this fiscal.

So with all this action happening, it seemed wise to take the plunge and find out what the fuss was all about. This test will help you decide which laser device is ideal for your business! We segregated the devices into three broad categories for the tests: colour

laser printers, mono laser printers and mono laser MFDs.

MONO LASER PRINTERS

The mono lasers, based on their duty cycles, were divided into two groups—with duty cycles of 15,000 pages per month and below, and those with duty cycles of over 15,000 pages per month.

The former category is aimed at the SoHo segment—SoHo printers aren't required to print many pages on a daily basis. Printers that could easily print in excess of 15,000 pages per month were put into the 'Workgroup' category—ideal for larger businesses that need a workhorse for a printing machine.

SoHo CATEGORY Features

The mono lasers (black and white) we received were surprisingly small and nothing like the bulky devices we are used to. Once unpacked, the extensive packing made us suspicious of their build quality.

The Samsung printers beat everyone quite comfortably, as they were the sturdiest of the lot—a noteworthy mention is the Samsung ML2250, which had a smooth, classy finish. Keeping with tradition, the Lexmark E230 looked sturdy and classy as well. This black-and-silver beauty will add to the looks of your designer office!

Once we were done with the exterior inspection, we proceeded to note down their other features. We started with the capacity of the paper trays—because all of us have, at some point or another, been in a rush to print out a report and seen the "Paper Tray Empty" message.

Judging by their compact build, we weren't too hopeful. Again, we were surprised! Almost all printers in this category matched the capacity of the Workgroup category—a 250-page tray.

The exceptions in this were the Canon LBP 2900 and WeP 1600, which had 150-page trays. In fact, WeP decided that even their workgroup printer would not need too many pages at once, and included only a 150-page tray in their WeP 2500 model.

The Canon LBP 2900 and Lexmark E230, allow you to add a paper tray; something the others don't. Not one of the printers we